

HOTSPOT

Goa's secluded beaches are a haven of drugs, rave and sex and a major market for foreign narcotics dealers. The state has come to mean free-flowing beer and dancing the night away by the shoreline.



HEMANT PITHWA

action. Issues like the presence of the drug mafia and the growing problem of prostitution, which were earlier swept under the carpet, are now coming to the forefront. With shacks being put under a tight deadline of 11.30 p.m. to shut down, the beaches of North Goa, home to most 24x7 nightlife and rave parties, are deserted by midnight and patrolled by policemen. Fashion designer Wendell Rodricks supports the move: "I am in favour of the deadlines; we can't give up our lives for the sake of tourism. The anti-narcotics squad are hand-in-glove with the drug mafia. The Government needs to take strict action," he adds.

Left red-faced after the investigating officer in the Keeling case was found guilty of suppressing the truth, the police are under pressure to crack down on illegal activities. The Morjim beach, known to locals as mini Russia, wears a deserted look, a far cry from the round-the-clock activity during the season. Cops start their beach patrol at sunset questioning people and demanding identification. "If the police find people roaming around at night, they question them and arrest those who can't give satisfactory answers," says Inspector General of Police Kishan Kumar. In the last 10 days, the police have arrested at least

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GANESHA SOMAYAJI,
SOCIOLOGIST

150 people. Popular nightclubs like Paradiso and Cubana are shut and locked and others allow entry only to couples.

The recent developments have set the alarm bells ringing for the tourism industry and the department is hard-selling the safety factor. Tourists with expired visas are being deported and beach patrolling has intensified. "We are concerned about the bad name Goa is earning because of this (Keeling) case and the police are cracking down on illegal activities," says Francisco Xavier Pacheco, Goa's tourism minister.

A weak administration and an unstable government are the cause of most evils in the state. In the past 20 years, Goa has seen governments toppling every few months. The 40-member House routinely witnesses MLAs switching parties to stay in power. "In the past three years, the assembly hasn't functioned properly for more than 20 days. Policy decisions and projects suffer because of this," says former chief minister Manohar Parrikar. Police officials blame the shaky government—constantly blackmailed by MLAs—for a demoralised and divided police force. Policemen are allegedly required to pledge loyalty to powerful leaders. In February this year, the police arrested a man for rowdy behaviour. Within hours, the police station was attacked